Yifan Xie

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Education

Ph.D. Agricultural and Resource Economics, University of California, Davis — Expected June 2027
Advisors: Jens Hilscher (Co-Chair), Bulat Gafarov (Co-Chair)
M.S. Agricultural and Resource Economics, University of California, Davis — 2022
Bachelor of Economics, International Economics and Trade, Hohai University — 2021

Research Fields

Primary: Food and Agricultural Economics; Consumer Behavior; Applied Microeconomics
Secondary: Health Economics; Firm Financial Analysis

Research and Work in Progress

"Delayed Substitution and Price-Tier Dynamics in Household Food Consumption" (*Job Market Paper*, with Bulat Gafarov and Jens Hilscher)

Using Nielsen Consumer Panel data (2004–2024), this paper shows that cheapflation, the faster price growth of budget-tier than premium-tier foods, is concentrated in downturns: it is strongest during the Great Recession and close to zero in normal times. We estimate substitution elasticities within a CES framework and use local projections to trace expenditure share responses over four quarters. Substitution is sluggish and takes about a year to build up. Low-income households substitute more than high-income households, and their substitution keeps deepening over the year. Expensive tiers carry higher implied markups, but price ratios between tiers are unrelated to markup ratios.

"Health Information and Food Purchasing Responses: Evidence from a Type 2 Diabetes Diagnosis" (with Kristin Kiesel)

Combines the Nielsen Consumer Panel with PanelViews survey data and employs a staggered difference-in-differences estimator. Finds that a diabetes diagnosis triggers significant, persistent reductions in non-fresh produce purchases, with sharp heterogeneity by income.

"Market Power and Food Price Pass-Through: Evidence from Restaurants and Grocery Retail" (*in progress*)

Links Datassential restaurant menu prices with Nielsen data to compare cost pass-through across sectors with different market structures, and builds food inflation measures covering food at home and away from home.

Publications

Xie, Y. (accepted) Exploring the impact of temperature anomalies, temperature variability, and trade openness on dietary diversity. *Frontiers in Nutrition.*

Xie, Y., Zhang, H., & Sikveland, M. (2025). Political connections and financing sources for firms under the COVID-19 pandemic. *Studies in Economics and Finance, 42*(5), 887–907. doi:10.1108/SEF-07-2024-0436

Xie, Y., Fang, Y., & Zhang, D. (2022). How environmental performance affects financial performance in the food industry: A global outlook. *Sustainability, 14*(4), 2127. doi:10.3390/su14042127

Zhang, D., & Xie, Y. (2022). Customer environmental concerns and profit margin: Evidence from manufacturing firms. *Journal of Economics and Business, 120*, 106057. doi:10.1016/j.jeconbus.2022.106057

Zhang, D., & Xie, Y. (2020). Synergistic effects of in-house and contracted R&D on export performance: Evidence from China. *Applied Economics Letters, 27*(1), 9–13. doi:10.1080/13504851.2019.1605582

Presentations

"Delayed Substitution and Price-Tier Dynamics in Household Food Consumption" 2026
AAEA Annual Meeting, Kansas City

"Health Information and Food Purchasing Responses: Evidence from a Type 2 Diabetes Diagnosis" 2026
AAEA Annual Meeting, Kansas City

Fellowships, Honors and Awards

Non-Resident Supplemental Tuition (NRST) Fellowship, UC Davis 2022–2026
Jastro & Shields Graduate Research Award, UC Davis 2025–2026
Summer Research Fellowship, UC Davis 2024, 2026
Academic Excellence Scholarship (3 years), Hohai University 2018–2020

Teaching Experience

Teaching Assistant, University of California, Davis 2022–2026

ARE 171 Principles of Finance
ARE 146 Economics of Business Regulation
ARE 115A Development Economics
ARE 133 Behavioral Economics
ARE 172 Managerial Economics
ARE 106 Econometric Theory & Applications

Research Experience and Service

Graduate Student Researcher, UC Davis 2026
Supervisor: Katherine Hauck
Digitized historical *Kansas City Grain Market* newspapers (1921–1995), converting printed futures prices, storage, delivery, and open interest tables into time series for empirical analysis of grain markets.

Graduate Coordinator, UC Davis 2026

Languages, Software and Research Methods

Languages: Mandarin Chinese (native); English (fluent)
Software: R, Stata, Matlab, Python, LaTeX
Research Methods: Difference-in-differences (staggered), Local projections, CES demand estimation, Panel data estimation

References

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